
SESSION 4B

SPIRITUAL BATTLE

WAR TIME VS. PEACE TIME MENTALITY

Given the reality of Spiritual warfare, it is no surprise that the Bible calls Christians soldiers.



2 TIMOTHY 2:3-4 (ESV)

³Share in suffering as a good soldier of Christ Jesus. ⁴No soldier gets entangled in civilian pursuits, since his aim is to please the one who enlisted him.

A soldier's life is completely devoted to his cause. He is not preoccupied with wealth accumulation, or pleasure-seeking. A true soldier is always aware of his identity as one who has been set apart to do battle when the day comes; he is no longer a civilian. He seeks to please Jesus, the "one who enlisted him."

An important element in the identity of a soldier for Christ is a certain stance against the entanglements of the world.

Note this theme in the following passages:



1 JOHN 2:15-17 (ESV)

¹⁵Do not love the world or the things in the world. If anyone loves the world, the love of the Father is not in him. ¹⁶For all that is in the world—the desires of the flesh and the desires of the eyes and pride of life—is not from the Father but is from the world. ¹⁷And the world is passing away along with its desires, but whoever does the will of God abides forever.

EPHESIANS 5:8-11 (ESV)

⁸for at one time you were darkness, but now you are light in the Lord. Walk as children of light ⁹(for the fruit of light is found in all that is good and right and true), ¹⁰and try to discern what is pleasing to the Lord. ¹¹Take no part in the unfruitful works of darkness, but instead expose them.

JAMES 4:4 (ESV)

⁴You adulterous people! Do you not know that friendship with the world is enmity with God? Therefore whoever wishes to be a friend of the world makes himself an enemy of God.

Review the verses and answer the questions below.

How is the world described in this passage?

What should the Christian stance be toward the world?

How do these passages apply to you personally?

REALITY OF SPIRITUAL BATTLE

Read the excerpt below on the practical implication of taking seriously the existence of Satan and the reality of spiritual battle.

A spiritual war is raging. The apostle Paul says, "For we are not fighting against flesh-and-blood enemies, but against evil rulers and authorities of the unseen world" (Ephesians 6:12 NLT). You are in the middle of that war. Whether your heart is peace-loving or warlike makes no difference. You can't get out of it. You can only choose whether to fight or to be mowed down as a civilian casualty.
[...]

WHERE WE STAND

When the allies invaded France on D-day, allied leaders knew it was all over for Hitler. With the Russian juggernaut hammering in from the east, and now the powerful allies coming in from the west and the south, Hitler's only possible future was absolute defeat. But the soldiers on the ground didn't feel like anything was over. Bitter battles lay ahead and blood would be shed. Many would die.

This is a partial analogy for our situation today in the church. Jesus won the decisive battle at the cross, as we'll see. But we still have a vicious enemy rampaging all over the world. Satan is just as dangerous as he ever was, even though his ultimate doom is assured.'

Battle is a common theme in the New Testament. Our battle today is part of a dramatic struggle that has gone on for thousands of years. As God's plan rolls up to our own day, we take our place as combatants in the struggle.

Many Christians prefer to see the church as the family of God or the loving community, and both are valid pictures. But we are also at war--a war we could easily lose in our locality, in spite of the fact that Satan was defeated in the final sense at the cross. And in war, people must either be willing to fight or face death or captivity. Satan's ultimate defeat will be small comfort, here and now, if we allow our lives and churches to be shattered in the meantime.

Whether Christians see their lives in the context of spiritual war becomes quickly evident. Before considering how this war works, and how to fight, consider how our outlook should change just from knowing that we are engaged in a spiritual war.

WARTIME VS. PEACETIME MENTALITY

The last time America fought an all-out war was World War II. During that struggle, the country had to devote its whole energy to win. The need for sacrifice and effort profoundly affected every person in the country. Although America has fought wars since then, none of them has been large enough to drive the whole country into a wartime mentality. Life went on as usual for most people during the smaller wars since. Most of us have grown up without ever knowing the need for a true wartime mentality.

The Bible tells us the church is locked in the grip of all-out spiritual warfare. But many of us in the church have never seen a spiritual wartime mentality either. Too often, today's church functions in a mentality suitable to peacetime, but utterly inappropriate during war.

Waste

During times of peace, someone might ask, "What's wrong with enjoying myself by accumulating some goods and possessions?" But in times of war, people need to mobilize everything they can for the struggle. We can enjoy ourselves after the war-if we win. But if we lose, our survival is at stake. During World War II, the government rationed daily goods carefully; rubber, copper, gasoline, and food were all grudgingly given out because the country

needed those things to fight the war. Civilians all over the country gathered up extra silverware, pots, pans, and other pieces of metal and turned them over to the military. They put their money into war bonds. People with a wartime mentality realize this is no time to indulge self and accumulate goods.

Sacrifice

During times of peace, it's reasonable to avoid suffering and hardship as much as possible. But war always involves extreme suffering and hardship. Whether fighting on the front line or behind the lines, people know they can't win a war without painful sacrifice and suffering.

Autonomy

A person enjoying peace could well say, "If I don't feel like showing up or putting out sometimes, that's my business." Yes, we live in a free society, but in war, failure to show up and do your part may be the difference between victory and defeat. Soldiers aren't free to show up only when they want to. War requires discipline. In war, failure to do your part could cost others' lives. During war the stakes couldn't be higher. Any force that accepts autonomous wartime attitudes is headed for defeat.

Individualism

During peacetime you could say, "I decide what goals to pursue and how to pursue them." But this won't do for war. Warriors come under a unified strategy and must comply with orders. Any force where people decide what to do on their own is a rabble, not an army. Yes, individual initiative is also important, but soldiers must exert initiative within the scope of the overall strategic goals.

Danger

People enjoying peace are glad that no particular danger faces them, and see no reason why people should perish before their time. But people in war face mortal danger every day, and many die violently. War is supremely dangerous.

Time-out

In peacetime, people may play sports; they tire, and then call time-out. But in war, there are no time-outs. Imagine yourself in one of the battles portrayed in the motion picture *Braveheart*. As the screaming line of Scots races forward, you step out in front of your troops and hold your hands up in a T. "Time-out!" you cry. Well, you can take a time-out if you want to, but they aren't going to give one. Actually, this would probably only make them charge even harder. In war, exertion may often be to the point of utter exhaustion.

IS THIS EXAGGERATION?

Is it fair to draw conclusions about the church based on analogies with all-out human warfare? Yes it is, and in fact the stakes are even higher in our war. People aren't just dying physically. Some lose their souls forever. Make no mistake: Satan destroys lives, both of Christians and non-Christians. We can expect spiritual warfare to be every bit as vicious and harsh as human war. Jesus promised his followers peace, but he referred to inner peace, not peace with God's enemy; as he warns, "Here on earth you will have many trials and sorrows" (John 16:33).

When the church ignores the reality of spiritual warfare, we suffer from slack, individualistic attitudes that weaken us and guarantee defeat. Evidence on all sides shows that many Christians and even entire churches live in a peacetime rather than a wartime mentality.

People with a peacetime mentality simply cannot understand what all the fuss is about. They feel happy to be Christians, but see their spirituality as mainly something to bring them comfort. The things of God deserve some attention when one has the time, but it's hard because "I have a lot of things to do." When peacetime Christians see others getting hard-core about God, they feel perplexed. Why get so extreme? In contrast, when believers accept what God tells us about our war, we see a sharpness and commitment that God can use to bring victory to the church.

The Imperatives of War

All wars have certain things in common, and spiritual warfare is no different. Consider some of the elements that go into winning a war.

Intelligence

One of the first rules of war is to know your enemy well enough to anticipate his moves. Combat intelligence has won many battles in the history of human warfare. At Midway, the Japanese had poor intelligence, while the Americans

knew how to read Japanese code. The result was a decisive defeat inflicted on Japan. America has recently seen the problems caused by its poor intelligence regarding weapons of mass destruction (WMDs) in Iraq.

One advantage we should have in our struggle with Satan is good combat intelligence. In 2 Corinthians 2:11, Paul says "We are not ignorant of his [Satan's] schemes" (NASB). Or are we? Unfortunately, many Christians cannot say with Paul that they know the schemes of Satan, and the result is extreme vulnerability.

Morale

While it may seem too obvious to say, those in war must be willing to fight. But this is not always the case. History is loaded with examples of smaller forces defeating larger ones mainly because the larger force had lost the will to fight. In World War II, a single British jeep herded in several thousand Italian prisoners during the North African campaign. These men would no longer fight.

Are we ready to face the savagery of an enemy who has destroyed human lives for thousands of years? We must not underestimate the fury of spiritual war. Any time the church moves ahead, the people of God pay a price. Many of our fellow believers have already become so bewildered and dismayed by the battering in this war that they will no longer "stand fire."

Satan actively undermines Christians' fighting spirit by sowing defeatism in their minds. He also tries to divert attention from important issues by baiting believers into taking undue interest in unimportant things. Christians caught up in fixation with entertainment, materialism, sex, or obscure theology cannot be effective combatants. Satan doesn't need to persuade us to bow down to him; all he needs is for us to back off a bit and relinquish our fighting spirit. Once believers stop taking the offensive, the initiative goes over to Satan.

Equipping

Christians need to be equipped to fight just like any force in war, and Scripture says church leaders are supposed to prepare God's people for works of service (Ephesians 4:12). God has provided Christians with an arsenal of powerful weapons (2 Corinthians 10:3-4), yet unless we learn how to wield them, our plight is pitiful. A country that sent its soldiers into battle armed with spit wads would be a farce. But we sometimes see churches sending their people into battle virtually unarmed—they are ignorant and inexperienced. This is a failure of leadership.

Warring forces also need reliable direction and reasonable plans. The plans need to be suitable for the situation and for the enemy in question. When a group unites around a good plan, it is in good position to win victories.

Defense

Successful offensives win wars, but defense is also important. There's nothing wrong with building a base of operations where people can rest and be refitted, where supplies can be gathered and stockpiled, and where plans can be considered and established. We are finite creatures, and we can't withstand the constant tension of slugging it out with crafty spirit beings unless we get refreshed. We also have to train people and nurture the young. Having a place where people can enjoy the safety of support and nurture is part of a winning strategy in all wars.¹

- Dennis McCallum, *Satan and His Kingdom: What the Bible Says and How it Matters to You*

What are some aspects of your life that give evidence that you are living with a "wartime" mentality?

What are some aspects of your life that show that you are living with a "peacetime" mentality?

¹ McCallum, Dennis. *Satan and His Kingdom: What the Bible Says and How It Matters to You*. Minneapolis: Bethany House, 2009. pp. 12-18.